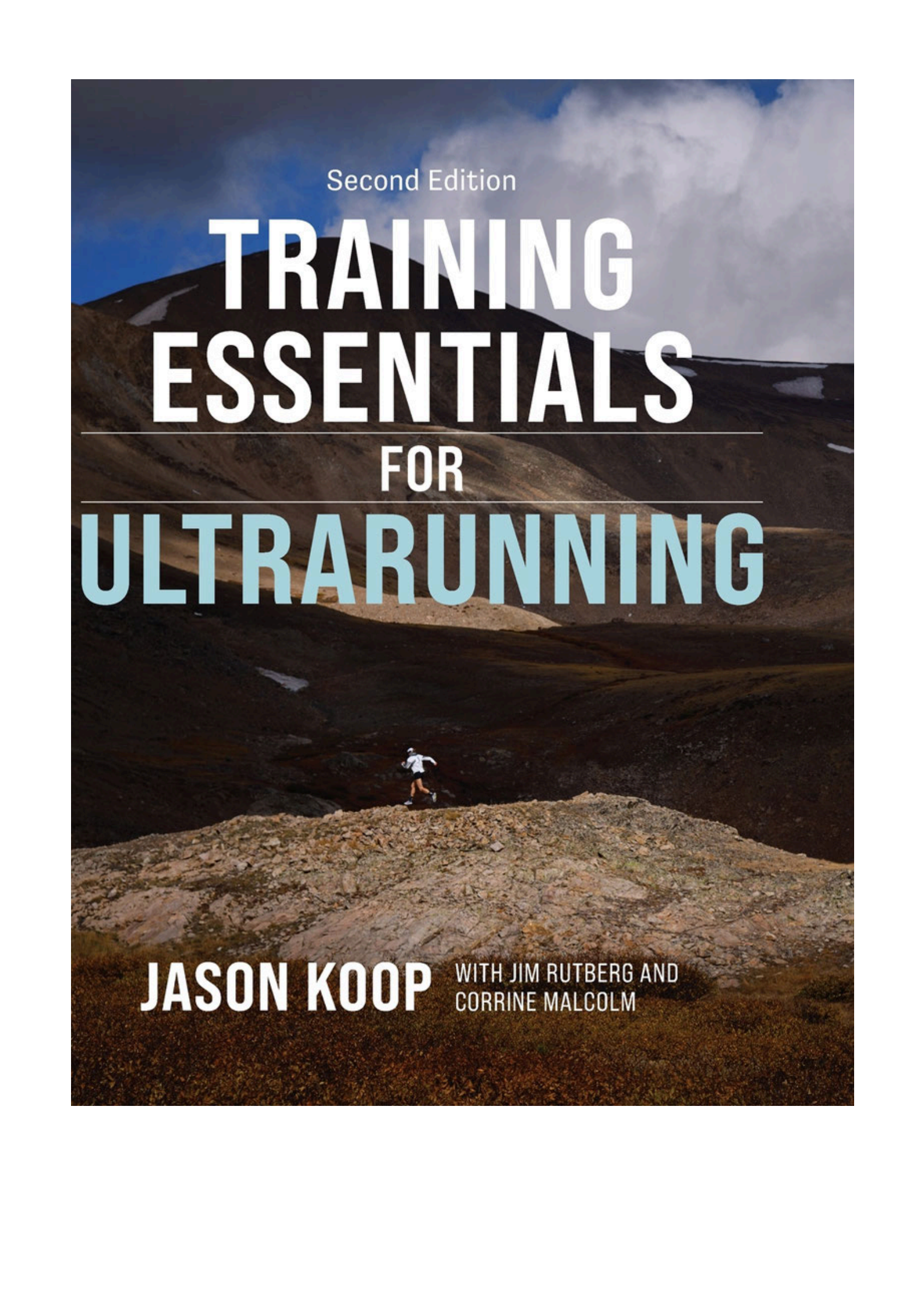


The background of the book cover is a photograph of a person running on a rocky ridge. The runner is wearing a white shirt and dark shorts, and is positioned in the lower center of the frame. The landscape is rugged, with dark, rocky slopes and patches of snow or light-colored rock. The sky is filled with large, white clouds, and a sliver of blue sky is visible at the top. The overall tone is adventurous and outdoorsy.

Second Edition

TRAINING ESSENTIALS

FOR

ULTRARUNNING

JASON KOOP WITH JIM RUTBERG AND
CORRINE MALCOLM

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**TRAINING
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**TO ACCESS A DIGITAL VERSION OF ALL OF THE FIGURES AND TABLES FROM THIS BOOK,
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For David, the most selfless person I have ever known.

May we all follow in your footsteps.

See you on Hope Pass!



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Foreword

BY KACI LICKTEIG

“I want to win Western States.”

Jason Koop was the first person I said that to. It might have been the first time I’d even said it out loud. It was the summer of 2014, and although I’d already achieved some success in two seasons as an ultrarunner, taking aim at the top step of the podium in the granddaddy of them all seemed like a giant leap. Putting it out there made it real, and having Jason in my corner made it feel possible. That’s what a coach does for you: they help expand your vision of what’s possible, not by telling you what you’re capable of but rather by guiding you to discover it within yourself.

My journey started in 2013, my first season running ultramarathons. I had transitioned from road marathons to trail running and experienced some success pretty quickly, but I could also tell that what I was doing wasn’t sustainable. I didn’t truly understand how to train for ultrarunning. Road marathons and trail ultras were very different, and I had a lot to learn.

When I won the 2013 Bear Chase 50 Mile outright, people started to take notice. I was introduced to Scott Jaime, who recommended that I contact a coach named Jason Koop. At the time, I had no idea who either of them was, so I didn’t act on the recommendation right away. As I continued to train on my own, however, I found myself wanting guidance and accountability, so I decided to reach out to Jason.

We had a great initial conversation. He asked me a ton of questions about my background, current and previous training, accomplishments, and goals. I similarly dug into his background and was reassured by his use of the latest scientific research, his coaching certifications, his personal experience as an athlete, and his rejection of “cookie cutter” training plans. What I truly loved was that he personally trains the same way he trains the athletes who work with him. He’s not a “do as I say, not as I do” coach. He does the workouts, runs the races, crews for runners, volunteers, and is active in the community.

I was excited to work with Jason, particularly because I had just earned a coveted spot into the 2014 Western States Endurance Run. As with any relationship, it took some time and patience for both of us to learn and adjust to each other. I was training at sea level, without a mountain in sight, for a 100-mile run featuring 18,000 feet of climbing, 23,000 feet of descending, and a peak elevation over 8,000 feet above sea level. I questioned plenty of things about his plan, and at every step he had solid science to back up what we were doing. Any remaining questions or doubts were put to rest on race day, when I ran around the Placer High School track to finish 6th in my first Western States.

It was shortly after that when I privately told Jason my ultimate goal and dream was to win Western States.

We went to work, and Jason was there through plenty of ups and downs. Two years later, on June 25, 2016, I achieved my dream. After 17 hours and 57 minutes, I ran around the track in Auburn, California, to win the Western States Endurance Run. I will never forget that moment, and I owe it to Jason for preparing me both physically and mentally for it. He will never take credit for his athletes’ accomplishments, but the performances speak volumes.

The Koop you’ll “meet” in this book is the same Koop I talk with on the phone. He’s a direct, brutally honest, no-nonsense scientist and coach who also has a tremendously compassionate, empathetic, and supportive side. He can be stern when it’s warranted, but he’s also the first person you want to see in an aid station when your day is going sideways, and he’ll be leading the cheering section when you cross the finish line. All of that passion, expertise, and perspective comes through in the pages of this book, which is why *Training Essentials for Ultrarunning* has helped so many new and experienced ultrarunners discover what they are truly capable of.



